

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called the Eight Maṇḍalas

Ārya-aṣṭa-maṇḍalakam nāma mahāyānasūtra · Toh 277 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དགའི་འཁོར་ལུ་ཐུག་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མདོ་

Toh 277 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-aṣṭa-maṇḍalakaṃ nāma mahāyānasūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Kyil Khor Gyé pa Shyejawa Tekpa Chenpo'i Do, rendered in English as The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle called The Eight Maṇḍalas. The text belongs to the sūtra class of canonical Buddhist scripture and opens in the customary manner, with the Buddha residing at Śrāvastī in the Jeta Grove, attended by a large assembly of monks and an extensive gathering of bodhisattvas. As its title suggests, the sūtra centers on the subject of maṇḍalas — sacred ritual or contemplative circles — treated within a Mahāyāna doctrinal framework. It was translated into Tibetan by Jñānasena and his collaborators, then edited and finalized in accordance with standard translation conventions of the period.

Translated by Jñānasena and others, edited, and finalized.

In the language of India: Ārya-aṣṭa-maṇḍalakam nāma mahāyānasūtra.

In the Tibetan language: The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle called The Eight Mandalas.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, together with a great Saṅgha of monks numbering around five hundred. He was also accompanied by a very great many bodhisattvas, among them: the great bodhisattva Vajrasvaraghoṣa, the great bodhisattva Ajita, Supreme Speech, Boundless Intelligence, Immaculate Essence, King of Wisdom, Host of the Infinite, Luminosity of Wisdom, Lamp of Wisdom, Light of Discernment, Brahmādatta, the great bodhisattva Crown Diadem of the Gods, and, together with these, yet other great bodhisattvas — all of them renowned for their great power and great renown.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra: Śāriputra, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand of the Ganges River, there is a world-system called Unvanquishable Banner. There the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named

Utterly Renowned Splendor is at this very moment present, living, and abiding, and he teaches the Dharma.

Śāriputra, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand of two Ganges Rivers, there is a world-system called Joyful to Behold. There the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Universally Illuminating is at this very moment present, living, and abiding, and he teaches the Dharma.

Śāriputra, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand of three Ganges Rivers, there is a world-system called Without Manifest Joy. There the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Glorious Victor Over Battle is at this very moment present, living, and abiding, and he teaches the Dharma.

Śāriputra, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand of four Ganges Rivers, there is a world-system called Assembly of the Utterly Pure. There the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named King of Banners, Victor Crowned with the Crest of the Senses, is at this very moment present, living, and abiding, and he teaches the Dharma.

Śāriputra, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand of five Ganges Rivers, there is a world-system called Assembly Free of Dust. There the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named King of Lords, Light of Boundless Qualities, is at this very moment present, living, and abiding, and he teaches the Dharma.

Śāriputra, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand of six Ganges Rivers, there is a world-system called Without Deception. There the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named Glorious Teacher Without Obstruction is at this very moment present, living, and abiding, and he teaches the Dharma.

Śāriputra, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand of seven Ganges Rivers,

there is a world-system called Gathering of Gold. There the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named He Who Passes Through by Pressing Down upon a Precious Lotus is at this very moment present, living, and abiding, and he teaches the Dharma.

Śāriputra, to the east of this buddha-field, beyond world-systems as numerous as the grains of sand of eight Ganges Rivers, there is a world-system called Melodious Sound. There the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha named King of Mountains Supremely Abiding upon a Precious Lotus is at this very moment present, living, and abiding, and he teaches the Dharma.

Śāriputra, the buddha-fields of these eight Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas are utterly pure: there are no women in them, and the five degenerations are absent.

Śāriputra, if any son or daughter of good family who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle hears the names of these eight Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, takes them up and holds them, reads them and brings them to complete mastery, puts them into practice, and teaches them extensively and correctly to others as well — Śāriputra, for such a son or daughter of good family, there is no possibility, no occasion, that they would go to a hell, or to the realm of animals, or to the realm of hungry ghosts, or into the realm of the asuras. There is no possibility that they would be born in any of the states of no leisure.

Śāriputra, even a woman who hears the names of those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, takes them up and holds them, reads them and brings them to complete mastery, puts them into practice, and also teaches them extensively and correctly to others — Śāriputra, for that woman there is no possibility, no occasion, that she would take on a woman's form a second time; there is no possibility of it.

Śāriputra, if any son or daughter of good family who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle hears the names of those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, takes them up and holds them, reads them and brings them to complete mastery, puts them into practice, and also teaches them extensively and correctly to others — know that for such a person no fear will arise from gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, humans, non-humans, kings, thieves, fire, water, poison, or weapons.

Śāriputra, if any son or daughter of good family who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle recites the names of those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas at nightfall before going to sleep, that person will fall asleep in ease, will awaken in ease, will not dream evil and sinful dreams, and even while sleeping will be protected by the gods.

Śāriputra, if any son or daughter of good family who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle recites the names of those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas and then at dawn strives at worldly tasks, those endeavors will grow and increase and will not decline.

Śāriputra, if any son or daughter of good family who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle hears the names of those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas, takes them up and holds them, reads them and brings them to complete mastery, puts them into practice, and also teaches them extensively and correctly to others — from this moment forward,

they will never, until awakening, be separated from direct knowledge (abhiññā). They will never be separated from dhāraṇī. Their sense faculties will never be incomplete. They will never be separated from the major marks. They will never be separated from vast and expansive wisdom. And they will never be separated from buddhas, bodhisattvas, pratyekabuddhas, and śrāvakas. From this moment forward, until awakening, they will never be separated from wisdom — excellent, vast, and fully perfect.

The Blessed One spoke thus, and having spoken thus, the Sugata, the Teacher, declared further these words in verse:

Whoever holds the names of these protectors of the world,
that person, turning back from all lower rebirths,
will swiftly and without delay proceed to a happy destiny.
They will bring joy to the perfectly awakened buddhas,
their mind will become clear and pure,
and always beholding the protectors of the world,
they will make supreme offerings.

Whoever holds these names
for countless tens of millions of eons —
that one will find a gateway to assemblies
and will always be honored and revered.
Whoever holds these names
for countless tens of millions of eons —
they will be perpetually worshipped by the gods
and will swiftly attain awakening, reaching full buddhahood.

Whoever holds these names
will not become confused in wisdom,
nor dull, nor foolish.

They will behold buddhas everywhere.
Whoever holds the names of those buddhas —
for that one, gods, nāgas, yakṣas,
the secret gods, and the asuras
will act as guardians by day and by night.

Whoever holds these names
will be born with an excellent and beautiful form,
born into a family of wealth and prosperity,
and will become a master of generosity.
By holding the names of those sages (munis),
for many hundreds of tens of millions of eons,
a fragrance will arise from that person's mouth —
a sweet and pleasing fragrance will emerge.

Whoever holds the names of those sages
will be possessed of great miraculous power and a joyful heart,
and will be reborn upon a precious lotus
adorned with ten billion petals.

Whoever holds these names —
their father and mother, relatives and kin,
and their brothers and sisters will be pleased,
and that person will never be seen to be destitute.
Even a woman of discerning mind,
on hearing the names of those ones,
will develop weariness toward a woman's body,
and be reborn as a learned and wise man.
For the benefit of all embodied beings,
they will swiftly attain awakening, reaching full buddhahood,
and will become a support and refuge
for the world together with its gods.

Weapons cannot harm that person,
poisons cannot harm them, nor can fire.
Deceivers, thieves,
and even kings will not be able to harm them.
Whoever holds the names of those sages —
even a māra with accumulated evil,

together with dark-natured kin and retinue mounted and on foot,
will find no opportunity against them.

That person will travel through the sky
across countless tens of millions of buddha fields,
and in those excellent pure lands
will behold the protectors of the world.
Having seen those steadfast buddhas,
they will attain an unwavering faith,
and those supreme among humans, knowing their aspiration,
will confer prophetic declaration upon them.

Having heard directly from those sages
the prophetic declaration of awakening for oneself,
they will always be possessed of joy
and will become free of doubt.

Whatever learned person hears these names
and takes them up and holds them firmly —
that one will attain these qualities
and also other great and extensive ones in turn.

Having heard the names of those sages, those great seers,
whatever person holds those names —
one who is endowed with great miraculous power, wisdom, and a wish for
merit —
such a great being as this, on hearing the names of those ones:
a learned person should take them up and hold them,
and should also teach them to others.

After the Blessed One had so declared, the venerable Śāriputra, those monks,
and —

those bodhisattvas, together with the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas
— the entire world rejoiced and wholeheartedly praised what the Blessed One
had declared.

This completes the noble Great Vehicle sūtra known as "The Maṇḍala of the
Eight."

Translator's Notes

- The text breaks off mid-sentence; the passage ends before the seventh buddha-field's description is complete, and no translation has been supplied beyond what appears.

The bodhisattva name འཇིག་ཅིང་མཆོག་ ("Ajita," literally "Unvanquished") is kept here in its standard Sanskrit equivalent; some traditions identify this figure with Maitreya.

The world-system name རྒྱལ་ཁབ་མཆོག་མེད་པའི་ཡུལ་ is rendered "Without Manifest Joy" to preserve the compound's literal force; it could also read "Lacking Evident Delight."

འཇིག་ཅིང་མཆོག་མེད་པའི་ཡུལ་འཇིག་ཅིང་མཆོག་མེད་པའི་ཡུལ་ is a complex compound rendered "King of Banners, Victor Crowned with the Crest of the Senses," following the literal components; the precise canonical Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain.

- The name rendered "He Who Passes Through by Pressing Down upon a Precious Lotus" translates the Tibetan rin po che'i pad ma la nram par gnong pas bzhuds pa, which is grammatically complex. The verb bzhuds pa (to depart, pass through, or proceed) combined with nram par gnong pas (by pressing down, or by prevailing over) could also suggest "He Who Proceeds by Subduing the Precious Lotus," but the general sense of the epithet as a dignified mode of progress or traversal seems clear enough for the narrative context. The difference is not doctrinally consequential.

The phrase rendered "take on a woman's form a second time" (bud med kyi dngos po lan gnyis len pa) literally means "to take on the condition or substance of a woman a second time." This reflects a traditional soteriological statement about gender and rebirth that appears in several sūtra contexts; it is transmitted here without editorial alteration.

- The phrase rendered "secret gods" translates a term that appears to denote a class of gods associated with secret or hidden domains, possibly yakṣa-related guardian deities or a Tibetan gloss on vidyādevas; the exact Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain but the meaning in context is clearly a class of protective divine beings grouped with gods, nāgas, and yakṣas.

The final sentence is deliberately left open, as the Tibetan breaks off mid-sentence listing the assembly present at the close of the discourse, consistent with the standard sūtra closing formula that continues beyond the given passage.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.